

known now, you're not preparing for the worst. And that is the cold hard truth.

FOUR QUESTIONS YOU NEED ANSWERED *BEFORE* THE END

You've heard the saying: nothing is certain except death and taxes. (Don't even get me started on the death tax.) Give the following list to your parents and discuss their answer to each question. Go over it with your partner, too.

1. **Do you have a will?** I don't care if you're only 30 years old: if you have kids, you need a last will and testament. Choose a lawyer you trust, someone who will write crystal-clear clauses that leave no room for misinterpretation. Your feelings about your prospective beneficiaries may change over time, but don't use that as an excuse to put it off indefinitely. You can always change your will—most people do at some point. Budget around \$300–\$400 for a lawyer to draw up a will (add an additional \$100 for a power of attorney). If you want a more cost-effective option, you can download a legal will on sites like [FormalWill.ca](https://formalwill.ca) for under a hundred bucks. If you don't have significant assets, tax concerns and multiple beneficiaries, this is often a great option. It covers all the basics, including whom you want to act as legal guardians of your children in the event of your death.
2. **Have you created a file for your surviving family members?** My father, George, has an actual file folder in his house with a label that says: TO BE CONSULTED ON MY DEATH. Both my brother, Shane, and I know exactly where it is. On the sad